

# Joan I of Aragon to the King of Cyprus — Homage for Cypriot Fiefs Deferred to the Coronation

## Document Summary

| Field                 | Detail                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |
|-----------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Archival reference    | ACA, Cancillería, reg. [to verify] (f. 2r-v per working filename)                                                                                                                                                                           |
| Date                  | Barcelona ( <i>Barchinona</i> ), 13 June 1387                                                                                                                                                                                               |
| Language              | Latin                                                                                                                                                                                                                                       |
| Document type         | Royal letter / missive ( <i>littera clausa</i> , sealed <i>sub sigillo secreto</i> )                                                                                                                                                        |
| Issuer                | Joan I of Aragon                                                                                                                                                                                                                            |
| Addressee             | The King of Cyprus (James I of Lusignan, r. 1382-1398), addressed by formula only as <i>illustris princeps et consanguineus carissimus</i>                                                                                                  |
| Principal third party | Hugo de Sancta Pace (Hug de Santa Pau?), miles, royal councillor of Joan I                                                                                                                                                                  |
| Subject               | Request that the King of Cyprus accept, through a proctor, the homage owed by Hugo de Sancta Pace for fiefs he holds in the kingdom of Cyprus, the noble being detained at Joan's court until the (deferred) coronation has been celebrated |
| Issuing authority     | <i>Franciscus ça Costa</i> (Francesc ça Costa, vice-chancellor)                                                                                                                                                                             |

## Reconciled Transcription

Orthography follows the scribe (-*ci*- forms retained throughout); standard abbreviations expanded silently; remaining uncertainties marked [?]; editorial supplements in square brackets.

Illustris princeps et consanguinee carissime. Per alias litteras nostras rogavimus, nunc eciam deprecantes magnificenciam vestram attentius, quatenus nobilem et dilectum consiliarium nostrum Hugonem de Sancta Pace, militem, nostris quidem serviciis continuis insisten[tem] [?], velitis [?] de accedendo ad presenciam vestram promitit<sup>1</sup> et eciam usque quoque, ut

prestaret homagium feudorum que per vos tenet in regno vestro Cypri, racionabiliter procuratum [?]. Hic enim fuit et est veritas quod nos, cum omnibus magnatibus regnorum et terrarum nostrarum ipsumque nobilem et alios barones, diu est vocari fecimus ad solempnia coronacionis nostre felicitis,<sup>2</sup> quia [?] de mense madii proxime lapso, sicut deliberavimus, celebrare nequivimus propter imminentem mei corporis distensiam,<sup>3</sup> licenciare ipsum nobilem noluimus, sicut nec voluimus, quousque dicta fuerit celebrata coronacio mea.<sup>4</sup> Cumque nondum persone mee infirmitas hoc permittat, idcirco expediat [ut] memoratum nobilem interim in mea curia residere. Benignitatem vestram affectuose rogamus quatenus prefatum homagium, ut placeat, per procuratorem nobilem eiusdem recipere, et ad se et sua hereda [sic] cum honoris respectu favorabiliter recom[mendetis] [?].<sup>5</sup> Et si qua, illustris princeps et consanguinee carissime, vestra occurrerint sub limitari [?] accepta, de quibus istis confidenter rescrib[atis] [?], quousque [?] et eos de vestris successibus prosperis — quos deus letos semper faciat et iocundos et notivos<sup>6</sup> — crebris scripcionibus nos reddentes. Datum Barchinone sub meo sigillo secreto XIII die junii anno [a] nativitate domini millesimo CCC<sup>o</sup> lxxx<sup>o</sup> vii<sup>o</sup>. — Franciscus ça Costa<sup>7</sup>

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## Annotated English Translation

Illustrious prince and most dear kinsman.<sup>8</sup> By our earlier letters we asked — and now also, entreating Your Magnificence more earnestly, we ask again — that you be willing [to receive] our noble and beloved councillor Hugo de Sancta Pace, knight, who is engaged in our continual service [?], regarding his coming into your presence, [as] he promises,<sup>1</sup> and indeed up to whatever point [is required], so that he might render the homage for the fiefs which he holds from you in your kingdom of Cyprus, [the matter having been] duly arranged through a proctor [?]. For this is and has been the truth: that we, together with all the magnates of our kingdoms and lands, and this same noble and the other barons, have this long while since had [them] summoned to the solemnities of our happy coronation;<sup>2</sup> [but] because in the month of May just past we were unable to celebrate [it] as we had resolved, on account of the pressing affliction of my body,<sup>3</sup> we have been unwilling to give this noble leave [to depart], just as we have not wished [to], until the said coronation of mine shall have been celebrated.<sup>4</sup>

And since the infirmity of my person does not yet permit this, it is therefore expedient that the aforesaid noble reside in our court in the meantime. We earnestly entreat Your Benignity that you may be pleased to receive the aforesaid homage through a proctor of this same noble, and that you may favourably [commend / receive] him and his heirs with regard for [his] honour [?].<sup>5</sup> And if anything, illustrious prince and most dear kinsman, should arise as concerns you [?], received within [your] bounds [?], concerning these matters write back to us confidently [?]; and [keep] us [informed] of your prosperous successes — which may God ever make glad and joyful and renowned<sup>6</sup> — making us aware [of them] by frequent letters. Given at Barcelona under my secret seal, the 13th day of June, in the year of the Nativity of the Lord 1387. — Franciscus ça Costa.<sup>7</sup>

### Key Unresolved Ambiguities

1. **insisten[tem]** (the former "Sistence" *crux*). The word describing Hugo's relation to Joan's *servicia continua* is abraded. *insistentem* ("engaged in, attending upon") fits sense and traces, but is not certain. The earlier HTR "in Sistence" is a fabrication (no toponym) and is rejected. [?]
2. **The velitis ... promittit ... usque quoque period.** The syntax does not resolve cleanly into a single grammatical subject; *promittit* (3rd sg.) sits awkwardly against *velitis* (2nd pl.). Sense is recoverable; precise construction is not. [?]
3. **racionabiliter procuratum.** The participle's agreement and exact reference (to the *homagium*? to the whole arrangement?) are uncertain; the *debet percipere* of the earlier HTR is rejected as unsupported by the strokes. [?]
4. **mei corporis distensiam.** Reading confirmed (per researcher); the precise medical sense of *distensio* remains open (swelling? colic? generic indisposition?). Historically: corroborates the documented deferral of Joan I's coronation beyond the planned May 1387 date. [?] **on meaning, not reading.**
5. **recom[mendetis].** Governing verb of *ad se et sua hereda* abraded; *recommendetis* conjectured on formulaic grounds. [?]
6. **sub limitari accepta.** The phrase in the closing "if-anything-should-arise" formula does not parse confidently; *limitari* and *accepta* may both be garbled. The functional sense of the topos ("if anything arises that concerns you, write to us") is clear; the literal reading is not. [?]
7. **et notivos.** Anomalous adjective in the final tricolon (see n. 6). Likely a scribal corruption; the intended third epithet is unrecovered. [?]

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### Items for Archival Follow-up

- **Register and folio number:** confirm the ACA Cancillería register and verify the f. 2r-v placement implied by the working filename.
- **Prosopography of Hugo de Sancta Pace:** identify the knight and his Cypriot fiefs. *Sancta Pace* invites the vernacular *Santa Pau* (the Catalan comital/noble family) — to be checked against the manuscript and against any Cypriot-fief evidence, since a Catalan noble holding fiefs in Lusignan Cyprus would be notable and should not be assumed from the name alone.

- **The Cypriot homage itself:** corroborate from Cypriot or Aragonese sources the existence of fiefs held by an Aragonese-orbit noble in the kingdom of Cyprus c. 1387, and the use of a proctor to render homage in absentia.
  - **Coronation chronology:** cross-reference the *mense madii proxime lapso* deferral against the established sequence of postponements of Joan I's coronation, and against any independent evidence of the king's illness (*corporis distensia*) in spring 1387.
  - **Direct collation** of the three readings most resistant to remote resolution: insisten[tem], recom[mendetis], and sub limitari accepta.
1. *promittit* (per your reading of the post-*accedendo* clause). The third-person singular intrudes oddly into a clause whose grammatical subject ought to govern *velitis*; the syntax of the whole period (*velitis ... de accedendo ... promittit et eciam usque quoque*) is loose, and the construction is best read as the chancery compressing two ideas — the king's willingness to receive Hugo, and Hugo's own undertaking to come. The sense is secure even where the syntax is not. ↩ ↩<sup>2</sup>
  2. *coronacionis nostre felicitis* (royal plural, *nostre*), per your adjudication. This resolves the earlier crux over a possible *coronacionis mee solius*: the document does **not** sustain a first-person-singular "coronation of myself alone." Note, however, the genuine alternation of grammatical person across the letter (plural *nos ... rogavimus ... deprecantes ... nequivimus ... noluimus*; singular *mei corporis ... persone mee ... mea curia ... sigillo meo ... coronacio mea*). The shift to the singular clusters specifically around the king's *body, person, court, seal, and coronation* — i.e., the intimate and personal — while the plural governs the formal acts of petition and decision. This is a scribal/registral pattern worth noting rather than a sustained ideological "voice," but it may be of interest to an argument about how Joan's personal authority is figured in his correspondence. ↩ ↩<sup>2</sup>
  3. *mei corporis distensiam*, per your reading of the word after *corporis*. *Distensio* (lit. "a stretching, swelling, distension") is not a classical term for illness, and its precise medical sense here is uncertain — it may denote a swelling, a colic or abdominal complaint, or be used loosely for "indisposition." The functional meaning is unambiguous: a bodily ailment that forced the postponement of the coronation. The earlier HTR reading *distensiam* is here confirmed against the image; my Stage-1/Stage-2 conjecture *dis[tem]p[er]anciam* is withdrawn. ↩ ↩<sup>2</sup>
  4. The clause division falls across the folio break (the words *celebrata / coronacio mea* span the two text blocks). *quousque dicta fuerit celebrata coronacio mea* = "until the said coronation of mine shall have been celebrated." ↩ ↩<sup>2</sup>
  5. The verb governing *et ad se et sua hereda* is uncertain. HTR's *recomisat* is not Latin; *recom[mendetis]* ("commend/receive favourably") fits the formulaic register and the surrounding subjunctives of request (*velitis, rogamus, recipere*), but the manuscript reading is abraded and the resolution is not secure. *hereda* for *heredes* is retained as the scribe's form [sic]. ↩ ↩<sup>2</sup>

6. *et notivos* per your reading. The word is problematic: *notivus* is not a standard classical or medieval Latin adjective. In a tricolon of the "may God make them glad, joyful, and \_\_\_" type, the third member should be another favourable adjective; *notivos* may be a scribal form for something in the *notus* family ("renowned, well-known") or a corruption of an expected word such as *iocundos et [festivos / votivos]*. Translated provisionally as "renowned." Flagged as an unresolved crux. ↩ ↩<sup>2</sup>
7. *Franciscus ça Costa* — Francesc ça Costa, vice-chancellor (*vicecancellarius*) of Joan I, here providing the *iussio* / issuing notation. His appearance is consistent with the chancery personnel of Joan's accession period. The vernacular *ça* (= *za* / "of the") is written as such in the subscription, not Latinized. ↩ ↩<sup>2</sup>
8. *consanguineus* ("kinsman") is the conventional inter-monarchical address between sovereigns and does not assert a specific genealogical relationship, though the Lusignan and Barcelona houses were indeed distantly connected. The vocative formula stands in for the addressee's name, which the register does not supply in the protocol. ↩